

STRESS, CORTISOL & THE URGE TO KEEP PUSHING.

When more effort stops being the answer.

Some stress is useful. Training is a stress. Deadlines can be a stress. The problem is the chronic, low-grade load that never switches off — combined with the belief that the solution is always to push harder. Cortisol is not the villain. Unrelieved load without recovery is.

EUSTRESS VS THE GRIND

Eustress is load you can adapt to: a hard session, a focused work block, a challenge with a clear end.

The grind is load without recovery: short sleep, under-eating, extra training “because I should,” work that spills into every evening, and the story that rest is weakness.

The body adapts to the first. It conserves and frays under the second.

WHAT KEEPS SHOWING UP

Flat energy. Stalled training. Sleep that does not restore. Drive that drops. Hunger or appetite that becomes chaotic. A shorter fuse.

These are not always “need more discipline.” They are often “the load has exceeded recovery for too long.”

× COMMON FOLLY

- × **Adding another session when recovery is already thin.** More training on a broken base digs the hole deeper. Sometimes the highest-return move is one less hard day, not one more.
- × **Wearing busyness as proof of commitment.** A full calendar is not the same as effective stress. Unprotected evenings and late screens keep the system activated when it needs the opposite.
- × **Blaming cortisol in isolation.** Cortisol is a normal messenger. The issue is chronic activation without enough sleep, food, and psychological off-ramps. Fix the inputs; do not only hunt the hormone.

PRACTICAL LEVERS

1. **Protect sleep** as non-negotiable recovery.
2. **Eat enough** for the load you are carrying.
3. **Remove one load** before adding a new habit — one training day, one late work block, one evening scroll window.
4. **Schedule real off time** the way you schedule work. If it is not in the calendar, it usually does not happen.

A SIMPLE TEST

For two weeks, keep training volume steady or slightly lower, sleep protected, and food adequate. Notice energy, mood, and session quality.

If those improve, the limiter was recovery, not lack of grit.

Pushing has a place. It works best when the system can absorb it.

Next step: Identify one chronic load you can reduce this week. Run it for fourteen days. Free programme at beinghaware.github.io/BHAFL.